

Foreword from IEEECS/ACM/CSI...

ACM / CSI / IEEE CS Research & Industry Symposium on IoT Cloud For Societal Applications (IoTCloud'21)

(In honour of Shri. F.C. Kohli, Father of Indian Software Industry)

Jointly organised by ACM Chennai, IEEE CS Madras & CSI Chennai in Association with AIC IIIT Kottayam & IIIT Kottayam on 3rd May 2021

The Information Technology Services and Software Industry in India was in its infancy during the 1960s. Computing activities were confined to few universities and research centres and to a small set of companies till then. It took the vision and competence of an intellectual giant called Shri F.C. Kohli to nurture and guide TCS, the newly setup computing arm of the Tata Group, to be a global leader in three decades.

He was a disciplinarian, patriot, visionary, and a scholar. He chose to recruit the nation's best minds from top universities, mentor them and challenge them to walk on uncharted territories.

He sought friendship and collaboration from leading academic institutions to build research competence within the firm. It led to the establishment of TRDDC in 1981 and 19 more TCS innovation labs in India and abroad over the next three decades. He was an active member in professional bodies such as IEEE, ACM and CSI and encouraged staff to organize and participate in every activity that would nurture a research and knowledge sharing mindset

In the process, he played a seminal role in placing India on the global map of service providers and rightfully earned the moniker, "The Father of the I.T. Industry in India". He remained active in service of the nation and the profession till he passed away in Nov 2020, at the age of 96.

There are many of us who owe our growth in person and in profession to him. It dawned on us that supporting the causes he advocated could be the best way to pay our tribute to this visionary and pioneer. One of his lifelong passions has been to bring the industry and academia together to advance the research competence in TCS and in the country. He worked with focus and commitment with many top-notch educational institutions to foster applied research. He knew that the developments would continue for decades and India must remain involved in cutting edge work, be it in traditional Software engineering or in state-of-the-art Analytics, AI, Speech recognition, Indian language processing etc.

Many of us at the Chennai chapters of CSI, ACM and IEEE CS have been the beneficiaries of his vision and wisdom over many decades. We have interacted with him and his team and have built our careers through his mentorship. This industry and research symposia series is borne out of our desire to honour him by keeping his mission in focus and in running mode.

Messrs. H.R. Mohan, Chair, ACM Chennai, P.V. Subramanian, Chair, CSI Chennai, P. Sakthivel, Chair, IEEE CS Madras and I deliberated in early January to evolve this proposition of sponsoring a series of symposia in Shri FCK's honour. The events would continue to build bridges between practitioners and researchers and advance technology applications in multiple areas. Eminent speakers would be invited to share their knowledge with young researchers and the latter would get an opportunity to present their work to get a feedback.

We deliberated as a team and decided on the four themes of Data Sciences & Analytics, Intelligent & Smart Systems, Cloud Computing, IoT, CPS, and Information & Cyber Security

“Practice what you preach” is an adage. We decided to seek collaboration with reputed institutions to organize these events. We found the first of such partners in AIC IIITK who shared our vision to

leverage technology for societal missions. We are thankful to the institute and Dr. Shajulin Benedict to have joined hands to organize the conference on IoT, Cloud, AI, and Applications. We also thank Fortess , a body of professionals who have been mentored by Shri FCK for its support.

With this event, we have placed the first stones to build this bridge between academia and industry and contributed to the cause of building our country's skills in advanced technologies by challenging best minds on high quality research. We trust the symposium provides young scholars the means to connect with other scholars, explore deeper into research areas of interest, and remain committed and motivated to serving the cause of scientific enquiry.

Dr. Parasuram Balasubramanian
Member, Advisory Committee